

Eiffel Tower

Once the world's tallest building, a flamboyant feat of 19th-century engineering that became a Parisian icon



The Eiffel Tower was created as a spectacular entrance for the Paris Exhibition of 1889, held to celebrate the centennial of the French Revolution. The tower was designed by employees of the company run by Gustave Eiffel (1832–1923), an engineer who had made a name for himself as a builder of bridges, viaducts, and railway stations. It was selected out of more than 100 competing designs for the exhibition entrance because it was thought to best symbolize a century of scientific and technological progress.

Factory construction

Rising to a height of 984 ft (300 m), the Eiffel Tower stood almost twice as tall as any previous human structure. It was constructed of 18,000 factory-made wrought-iron pieces, brought to the site along the River Seine for assembly and joined together with 2.5 million rivets. Its wrought-iron latticework marked a radical departure from traditional

monumental buildings in brick or stone. Parisian aesthetes pretended to hate it, protesting against the “useless and monstrous” tower that would ruin “the hitherto untouched beauty of Paris.” However, the public loved it from the start, almost 2 million people flocking to buy tickets to mount the tower during the 6 months of the exhibition.

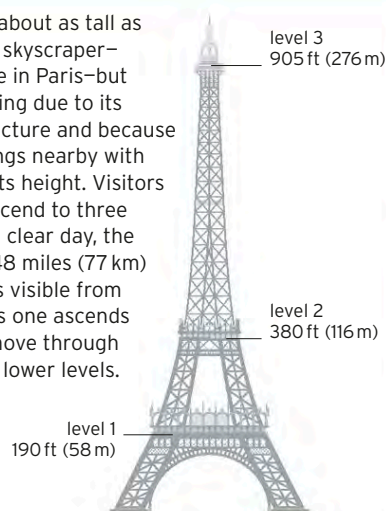
New purposes

Gustave Eiffel had a 20-year contract to capitalize on the tower commercially, after which it was supposed to be dismantled. However, the placing of a radio transmitter on the top in 1904 gave it a practical use that saved it from destruction. The tower was surpassed as the world's tallest structure by the Chrysler Building (see p.42) in New York in 1930, but its prestige as the symbol of the city of Paris has continued to grow. In the 21st century, it is one of the world's most visited tourist attractions.

Four **restaurants** on the **first floor** of the tower served hungry visitors during the **Paris Exhibition**

VIEWING LEVELS

The Eiffel Tower is about as tall as a modern 90-story skyscraper—the tallest structure in Paris—but appears less imposing due to its delicate lattice structure and because there are no buildings nearby with which to compare its height. Visitors to the tower can ascend to three viewing levels; on a clear day, the town of Chartres—48 miles (77 km) to the southwest—is visible from the highest level, as one ascends on elevators that move through a curved arc at the lower levels.



△ IN THE MAKING

A few small steam cranes; 12 temporary wooden scaffolds, each 98 ft (30 m) high; and four larger scaffolds, each 130 ft (40 m) high, were used to assemble the first level of the tower.

